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Revenue Model

How Argus makes money across the full product suite, phased to the Corp A/B/C compliance ramp — growth-first, with benchmarked lines and illustrative scenarios.

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Strategic guidance only — not legal, financial, tax, or investment advice.
Securities, money-transmission, and corporate-formation decisions must be reviewed by licensed counsel and a CPA before you act. Sections flagged “see counsel” are where this matters most.

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Revenue Model — full product suite, phased to the compliance ramp

How Argus makes money, product by product, gated by the phase that legally unlocks it. Growth-first: the collectibles wedge **acquires**, the wallet **retains**, the stack **monetizes** as you cross-sell into a trusted base — and the agent-operated cost structure lets you price below incumbents.

How to read this. Companion to `GTM-COLLECTIBLES-LAUNCH.md` (which sequenced the *marketing* waves — this sequences the *money*), `LAUNCH-READINESS.md` (the prod-fatal switches that gate each line), and `CORPORATE-STRUCTURE.md` (the Corp A/B/C ramp). Tags: **DO NOW, DEFER → Corp B/C**, ⚠ **see counsel**.

⚠ **Illustrative — not financial or legal advice.** Fee/take-rate figures are benchmarked planning estimates (vs. eBay/Stripe/Chime/Robinhood), not quotes; projections in §4 are **illustrative**, not forecasts. Interchange, net-interest-margin, FX, securities, and lending lines each require counsel/CPA (`CORPORATE-STRUCTURE.md` / `GO-LIVE-PLAN.md`).

1 1. The revenue thesis

Land-and-expand. Don't monetize the wedge — monetize the *stack*. Win users with cheap, high-trust collectibles (low take rate vs. eBay) and a zero-interchange rail, then earn as each downstream product attaches to a base that already trusts you. Three structural advantages:

- **The wedge is sticky and supply-moated** (graded slabs + provenance), so acquisition cost stays low.
- **ARPU compounds:** a collector who also holds a USD balance, taps a card, sends cross-border, and buys an RWA is worth multiples of a single-product user — and each attach is a *new revenue line*, not a discount.
- **The agent-operated cost structure** (PRD target <\$0.50/MAU operating cost) is a durable **margin** advantage: Argus can undercut incumbents on price and still make money, because the back office is agents, not headcount.

The honest spine — revenue follows the licence, not the code:

Phase	What you can charge	Shape
A (now)	Software/SaaS only (subscriptions, tokenization, promotion) — no transaction take rate	Thin
B (partnered)	Marketplace take rate + interchange + net-interest-margin + FX spread	Inflection
C (licensed)	Brokerage/RWA + lending + own-rail economics (recapture the partner share)	Compounding

You **cannot book revenue from a switch that's off** (`LAUNCH-READINESS.md` §3). The plan is sequenced so every line turns on only when its gate clears.

2. Revenue by phase (the core)

Phase A — non-custodial software, no customer funds (DO NOW)

The only thing you can charge for without being a money business is **software/SaaS revenue you keep** — *not* a take rate on a peer sale (that's intermediation = Corp B). Honestly thin until the marketplace goes transactional, consistent with the GTM "audience-now, launch-at-Corp-B" timing.

Line	Mechanism	Benchmark	Gate
Argus Plus/Pro subscription	Monthly collector tier (price alerts, agent discovery, portfolio view, priority authentication)	~\$5–15/mo (PRD plans tiers; free tier at launch)	Phase A
Tokenization / authentication fee	Flat per-slab fee to mint provenance (a software service, not a sale)	~\$1–5 / slab	Phase A
Featured listing / promotion	Seller pays to boost placement (software)	flat or tiered	Phase A
Provenance / data services	API/report access to authenticated history	per-call / tier	Phase A

Phase-A monetization is **revenue you collect for software** (Stripe processes *your* revenue — that's not money transmission). It is **not** a cut of buyer→seller funds; that needs escrow + Corp B.

Phase B — partnered: BaaS bank + FinCEN MSB + custodian (the inflection)

Line	Mechanism	Benchmark	Gate (switch)
Collectibles marketplace take rate ★	Seller fee on each escrow-protected sale	~2–5% (vs. eBay ~13%, auction houses ~20%+)	COLLECTIBLES_ESCROW_ENABLED 𐄂
Card interchange	Share of interchange on debit spend	~1.0–1.5% of spend (Durbin-exempt partner BIN)	CARDS_ENABLED 𐄂
Net interest margin / float	Yield earned on idle USD balances via partner-bank sweep (you keep the spread)	a few % of balances × NIM	BANK_RAILS_ENABLED 𐄂
FX spread	Markup on currency conversion (the built <code>FX_SPREAD_BPS</code> ~50bps + cross-border markup)	~0.5–1.5%	FX_ENABLED / FX_SETTLEMENT_ENABLED 𐄂
Instant/expedited + ACH/wire fees	Optional fee for instant withdrawal; wire fees	\$ flat per txn	BANK_RAILS_ENABLED 𐄂
Bill-pay	Small fee or float on scheduled payments	\$ flat / float	BILLPAY_ENABLED 𐄂
Argus Pay	Zero rail fee (the wedge — do not add interchange) → monetize via merchant SaaS / premium	\$/merchant/mo	ARGUS_PAY_ENABLED 𐄂

The marketplace take rate is the flagship Phase-B line; interchange + NIM + FX are the "boring bank" lines that turn a marketplace user into a primary-account ARPU. **Argus Pay stays free** — it's an acquisition/retention rail, not a revenue line (the wedge from `PAYMENT-NETWORK-STRATEGY.md`).

Phase C — licensed: own MTLs, broker-dealer/ATS, transfer agent (compounding)

Line	Mechanism	Benchmark	Gate (switch)
Brokerage	Commission/spread + margin interest + a Gold-style subscription	sub ~\$5–10/mo; margin ~5–11% APR	<code>TRADING_ENABLED</code> 𐄂
RWA / tokenized equities	Issuance fees + secondary-trading take rate + AUM/management-fee share + dividend/corporate-action processing	bps on AUM + take rate	<code>EQUITIES_ENABLED</code> 𐄂
Collateralized lending	Interest spread on RWA-backed loans	spread over cost of funds	(PRD v2) 𐄂
Own-rail economics	Recapture the partner share once you hold the licences (interchange, MT, custody); the Wyoming SPDI custody-at-scale option	margin recapture	Corp C 𐄂
Starter (teen/family)	Family subscription + (gated) interchange on teen cards	~\$5–10/mo/family	<code>TEEN_ENABLED</code> 𐄂

3. The ARPU stack & unit economics

Revenue compounds because each wave adds a line, not a discount. Illustrative **per-user revenue stack** (benchmarked, monthly, blended):

Collector only (Phase A):	subscription (a few \$)	→
+ Marketplace buyer/seller (B):	+ take rate × trade volume	→
+ Primary account (B):	+ interchange × spend + NIM × balance + FX spread	→
+ Investor (C):	+ brokerage/RWA take + AUM share	→

- **Attach rate is the master lever** — the same MAU is worth 3–5× more when card + balance + FX + RWA attach. Growth-first spend should buy *attach*, not just signups.
- **Margin moat:** with operating cost targeted <\$0.50/MAU (agents, not headcount; PRD), even thin per-line take rates clear healthy contribution margin — the structural reason Argus can price under Robinhood/Chime/eBay and still profit.

4. Illustrative projection scenarios (*illustrative — not a forecast*)

No real traction exists yet; these show the **shape** (an S-curve gated by licensing) and the **levers**, not a prediction. Inputs are blended-ARPU × MAU × attach; treat the numbers as placeholders.

	Year 1 (Phase A)	Year 2 (Corp B)	Year 3 (Corp C)
Live revenue lines	subscriptions, tokenization	+ marketplace take, interchange, NIM, FX	+ brokerage/RWA, lending, own-rail
Low	nominal (waitlist + founding sellers)	modest (marketplace ramps)	meaningful (stack attaches slowly)
Base	thin but real	inflection (take rate + interchange carry it)	compounding (ARPU 3–5× via attach)
High	small	strong marketplace + primary-account attach	full-stack ARPU + own-rail margin

Sensitivity (what actually moves the model): (1) **attach rate** across waves, (2) **marketplace take rate** vs. the eBay-beating promise, (3) **MAU** from the guerrilla wedge, (4) **NIM/interchange** terms from the partner bank, (5) **Corp-B/C timing** — every Phase-B/C line is zero until its licence lands.

5. Compliance coupling — revenue you can't book until the gate clears

Every line is gated by a prod-fatal switch (`LAUNCH-READINESS.md` §3) and a Corp phase. This reconciles 1:1 with the GTM rollout waves (`GTM-COLLECTIBLES-LAUNCH.md` §6).

Revenue line	Switch	Phase
Subscriptions / tokenization / promotion	(none — software)	A
Marketplace take rate	COLLECTIBLES_ESCROW_ENABLED	B ʘʘ
Card interchange	CARDS_ENABLED	B ʘʘ
NIM / float, ACH/wire/instant	BANK_RAILS_ENABLED	B ʘʘ
FX spread	FX_ENABLED / FX_SETTLEMENT_ENABLED	B/C ʘʘ
Bill-pay	BILLPAY_ENABLED	B ʘʘ
Argus Pay (merchant SaaS only)	ARGUS_PAY_ENABLED	B/C ʘʘ
Brokerage	TRADING_ENABLED	C ʘʘ
RWA / equities	EQUITIES_ENABLED	B/C ʘʘ
Teen/family	TEEN_ENABLED	B/C ʘʘ

6. Flag-and-avoid — the edgy revenue lines

Three tempting lines that **conflict with the brand and/or carry regulatory risk**.

Recommendation: **avoid or defer-with-counsel**.

- **PFOF (payment for order flow)**. Tempting "free trading" economics, but it's under regulatory scrutiny, optically toxic, and **contradicts the PRD anti-positioning** ("not an investing app, no advice, marketplace not exchange"). **Avoid** — monetize brokerage via transparent commission/spread + margin + subscription instead. ʘʘ
- **Marketed yield-on-balances**. Paying advertised "yield" on customer balances can make the balance look like an **unregistered security** (and intersects the GENIUS-Act stablecoin regime). Earn **net interest margin** quietly via the partner-bank sweep (\$2 Phase B), but **do not market a yield** as a product feature without securities counsel. **Defer** ʘʘ.
- **Data monetization**. Selling/sharing user behavioral data breaks the **trust moat** that the whole authentication/provenance brand is built on, and triggers GLBA/CCPA exposure. **Avoid** — data powers *your* product (discovery, fraud), it is not a product you sell. ʘʘ

7. Margin moat & risks

The moat is margin, not a single line. The agent-operated back office (support/compliance/ops at <\$0.50/MAU) lets Argus run thin take rates profitably — the durable advantage incumbents bolt on later and can't match on cost structure.

Risk	Mitigation
Take-rate compression (race to zero vs. eBay/incumbents)	Win on trust + provenance + escrow , not just price; the cost moat protects margin
Interchange caps / Durbin	Use a Durbin-exempt partner BIN; don't over-index on interchange
Incumbent copy (Robinhood/PayPal)	Supply moat + the agent-cost advantage + the one-app cross-sell
Regulatory shift (stablecoin/securities)	Keep the brand-safe lines; flag-and-avoid §6; counsel-gate every regulated line ⚡
Corp-B/C timing slip	Revenue is gated on licensing — fund the runway accordingly; the GTM keeps the audience warm with the Phase-A product

8. The one-line model

Subsidize the collectibles wedge to acquire a trusted base; monetize the stack — marketplace take, interchange, net-interest-margin, FX, then brokerage/RWA and own-rail margin — one compliance unlock at a time; and out-margin everyone because the back office is agents, not headcount.

Companion documents: [GTM-COLLECTIBLES-LAUNCH.md](#) (the marketing waves these revenue lines attach to), [LAUNCH-READINESS.md](#) §3 (the prod-fatal switches gating each line), [CORPORATE-STRUCTURE.md](#) (Corp A/B/C), [RAILS-CURRENCY-STRATEGY.md](#) (the FX spread), [PAYMENT-NETWORK-STRATEGY.md](#) (the zero-interchange Argus Pay wedge), [argus_prdv1/00](#), [/02](#) (subscription tiers + fee-structure positioning).